

STAGE NINE • ENGLISH VOCABULARY FIRST SET

FIRSTS

FACILITATOR NOTES / SCRIPT

Suggested language for openings, transitions, and prompting discussion

A Citrus Edition Facilitator Resource • Companion to the FIRSTS Manual

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FIRSTS • Facilitator Notes / Script

Stage Nine • English Vocabulary First Set

HOW TO USE THIS SCRIPT

This document is written for a first-time or less confident facilitator who wants actual suggested language, not just a topic list. Everything in quotes is meant to be read close to verbatim, or adapted lightly into your own voice.

This is a language-instruction stage, which brings its own specific dynamics: participants correcting mid-sentence, visible self-consciousness about accent or fluency, and genuine nervousness during live speaking drills. Part 3 and Part 4 lean into this directly — expect to draw on this document more actively than in a purely reflective stage.

It's organized into four parts: session openings, transitions between FIRSTS, discussion prompting for five situations specific to vocabulary instruction, and tricky moments flagged at specific FIRSTS where participants commonly feel exposed or stuck.

Part 1 — Session Openings

Opening Session 1

“Welcome to Stage Nine. This stage is different from the others: we're not reflecting on who you are, we're building a genuinely usable vocabulary for professional English — written and spoken.”

“One rule that applies all stage long: recognizing a word is not the same as being able to use it. Every session, I'm going to ask you to actually produce it — out loud or in writing — not just nod along.”

“This first session is long and covers ten separate word lists. We'll take a real break partway through, and if we need to, we can split the rest across an extra sitting rather than rushing.”

Opening Session 2

“Today shifts from broad vocabulary to specifically written, formal register: email, reports, meeting notes, decisions, findings. Everything today should be genuinely usable in something you're already writing this week.”

Opening Session 3

“Today is entirely spoken vocabulary, and it's a long, pair-work-heavy session. Expect to be talking, in pairs and small groups, for most of the next two hours.”

“One heads-up on structure: this session's FIRSTS aren't in strict numeric order — that's intentional, matching how the manual groups related vocabulary together. Don't worry if the numbering jumps around.”

Opening Session 4

“Today we build a full presentation's vocabulary, start to finish — opening, structure, emphasis, audience engagement, handling questions, and closing with a genuine ask. By the end, you should be able to chain all six lists into one coherent talk.”

Opening Session 5

“This is our shortest session — just four vocabulary sets, all focused on the first few moments of a professional interaction: greeting, introducing yourself, small talk, and everyday workplace expressions.”

Opening Session 6 (Stage Close)

“Our final session covers the vocabulary of working through a real problem: naming a challenge clearly, proposing solutions, weighing trade-offs, brainstorming, and reflecting honestly on what you've learned.”

“This closes the entire stage. By the end, I want you to be able to name at least one word or phrase from across these thirty-eight FIRSTS that you know you'll actually keep using.”

Part 2 — Transitions Between FIRSTS

A few sentences said out loud between vocabulary sets and between sessions turns a series of word lists into a coherent, connected skill.

FIRST M5 → M6

"We've covered written and general workplace phrases. Let's shift specifically to presentation vocabulary — language for guiding a room, not just a page."

Session 1 → Session 2

"Today was broad, foundational vocabulary. Next session narrows in specifically on written, formal documentation — email, reports, meeting notes."

FIRST M13 → M14

"You can now correctly label a decision versus an action item versus discussion. Let's go one level deeper: how do you document a decision so it's genuinely unambiguous?"

Session 2 → Session 3

"Everything so far has been written vocabulary. Today, we go live — the vocabulary of real, spoken, in-the-moment conversation."

FIRST M17 → M22

"You've just practiced advocating for a position live. Now let's talk about what happens after that conversation — the vocabulary of following up."

FIRST M25 → M38

"You've practiced basic feedback and listening vocabulary. Let's close this section by raising the difficulty — the vocabulary for a genuinely higher-stakes feedback conversation."

Session 3 → Session 4

"You can now hold a live conversation with precision. Today scales that up to a room: the full vocabulary of a presentation, start to finish."

FIRST M28 → M29

"You've just practiced making sure a point genuinely lands. Now let's turn the presentation from one-way delivery into something more like a real exchange."

Session 4 → Session 5

"You can now deliver a full presentation confidently. Today zooms all the way back in — to the first ten seconds of any professional interaction."

Session 5 → Session 6

"You now have vocabulary for first impressions, written formality, live conversation, and full presentations. Our final session is about working through something hard: naming a real problem and learning from it."

FIRST M35 → M36

"You've just practiced weighing real trade-offs on an existing option. Let's zoom out: what if the existing options aren't good enough yet? That's what brainstorming vocabulary is for."

Part 3 — Prompting Discussion in the Moment

Five situations specific to language instruction, with suggested language for each.

A participant uses a word incorrectly during practice

“Good attempt — let's actually look at that one together. [Correct usage explained.] Try the sentence again with that adjustment.” (Correct in the moment, warmly, and have them immediately re-attempt rather than just noting the error and moving on.)

Someone feels self-conscious about their accent or non-native phrasing

“This vocabulary is about precision and clarity, not about sounding like any one particular accent. A clear, correctly used word in your own natural voice is exactly the goal.”

The room goes quiet during a live speaking drill (M16, M26, etc.)

“That's genuinely one of the harder moments in this whole stage — speaking on the spot. Take a breath, and remember there's no wrong way to start; we'll build from wherever you begin.”

A participant insists a word they've been using is correct, despite a real error

“Let's actually check that together” (look it up together, live, rather than simply asserting the correction — seeing it confirmed independently lands better than being told).

Someone finishes vocabulary drills much faster than the group

“While others finish up, try using two or three of these words in a genuinely more complex sentence than the example — push the difficulty up rather than waiting idle.”

Part 4 — Tricky Moments by FIRST

Four points in this stage where participants commonly feel exposed, self-conscious, or stuck — and language to navigate each moment.

FIRST M9

10 Common Academic/Business Idioms

FACILITATOR NOTE

Idioms can be genuinely disorienting for participants still building English fluency, and some may feel embarrassed not recognizing common ones. Normalize this explicitly: idiom fluency often takes years of immersion, and comprehension alone (without ever needing to use them yourself) is a completely legitimate goal for this list.

FIRST M16, M26

Meeting/Call Vocabulary & Presentation Introduction (live speaking)

FACILITATOR NOTE

These are the first genuinely public-speaking moments in the stage and often produce visible nervousness. Keep the actual stakes low — short, low-pressure attempts with fast, kind correction — rather than treating early attempts as a performance to be judged.

FIRST M20

Self-Introduction Vocabulary

FACILITATOR NOTE

Removing hedging language can feel genuinely uncomfortable for participants whose cultural or personal communication style favors modesty. Frame this as calibration for a specific professional context, not a universal personality change — the skill is knowing when to hedge and when not to, not eliminating hedging altogether.

FIRST M38

Advanced Constructive Feedback

FACILITATOR NOTE

This is deliberately the hardest feedback vocabulary in the stage. If a participant seems to be drawing on a genuinely difficult real feedback memory during practice, don't press for the specific story — the vocabulary practice doesn't require disclosing what actually happened.